With this level of attachment of Pakistanis to the nuclear programme, any inkling of threat to the nuclear programme irks and upsets them to the hilt. An apprehension was rampant among the public that a superpower might try to snatch or neutralise Pakistan's nukes. This perception overshadowed the threat of terrorists trying to steal these nukes. The Pakistan Army did not endorse this public perception openly, but it had always been very conscious about the protection of the nuclear programme from any foreign attack from its very inception. Previously, there had been strong apprehensions of Israeli plans to attack Pakistan's nuclear plant. This worry had cropped up after Israeli jets attacked the Iraqi nuclear facility. Strangely, the threat from India came later as the army and public had a perception that India lacked the courage and the capability to attack Pakistan's nuclear facility. However, the apprehension kept lurking in the minds of the public and the army that India might try to get it done with the help of Israel.

These threats, perceived and actual, had been a blessing to sensitise Pakistan to ensure foolproof security measures for the protection of its nuclear programme and arsenal. It adopted a multilayered security system for the protection of nukes. Pakistani nuclear doctrine called for the warheads (containing an enriched radioactive core) and their triggers (sophisticated devices containing highly explosive lenses, detonators and krytrons) to be stored separately from each other and from their delivery devices (missiles or aircraft). The goal was to ensure that no one could launch a warhead – in the heat of a showdown with India, for example – without pausing to put it together. Final authority to order a nuclear strike required consensus within Pakistan's ten-member National Command Authority, with the Chairman – by statute, President of Pakistan – casting the deciding vote. National Command Authority (NCA) was established in 2000 for the command and control of Pakistan's strategic nuclear forces and for developing a nuclear policy (Khan, 2011).

Hersh (2009) quoted General Musharraf that Pakistan had constructed a nuclear attack-proof huge tunnel system for the transport and storage of nuclear weaponry. Pakistan's former Chairman Joint Chiefs of Staff Committee General Tariq Majid in a statement called Hersh's statement 'absurd and plain mischievous'. 'We have operationalised a very effective nuclear security regime which incorporates very stringent custodial and access controls.' 'As overall